Nurse Education in Practice 38 (2019) 72–78

Contents lists available at ScienceDirect

Nurse Education in Practice

journal homepage: www.elsevier.com/locate/nepr

Clinical education

Using blackboard collaborate, a digital web conference tool, to support nursing students placement learning: A pilot study exploring its impact

Tania Hart[a,*], David Bird[†], Robert Farmer[b]

[a] The Faculty of Health and Life Sciences, The Edith Murphy Building, De Montfort University, The Gateway, Leicester, LE1 9BH, UK
[b] The University of Northampton, Waterside Campus, University Drive, Northampton, NN1 5PH, UK

ABSTRACT

Ensuring student nurses, when in clinical placement areas, receive good quality Higher Education Institution (HEI) lecturer support is challenging. This is because conventional HEI placement support, is resource intensive and arguably infeasible with growing student numbers.

Evidence suggests, however, that online collaborative learning solutions (e.g., virtual classrooms, web conferencing tools) have the potential to ameliorate resource pressures. To test this idea, an online learning solution called Blackboard Collaborate was piloted. It virtually connected, students and their preceptors to a university lecturer. Its usefulness was explored by obtaining qualitative, focus group data, from the students and preceptor participants. The findings were thematically analysed.

Collaborate ensured all three parties were connected. It was a time efficient, easy to use technology. Despite technical glitches, i.e. occasional time delay and audio echo, participants concluded Collaborate was an efficient medium when placement needs were routine. Face-to-face was preferable when more intensive support was required.

In today's busy times, HEI's must explore time effective methods of placement collaboration. Online collaborative tools are one solution. Students will, however, need to develop their digital literacy in using this technology. The benefit being when qualified they are more likely to embrace this form of technology to promote their efficiency.

1. Introduction

Much of a student nurse's pre-qualification learning is spent acquiring skills and knowledge in the clinical environment. Many best practice nurse-training guidelines recommend that students in practice settings are overseen and supported by a more experienced, qualified healthcare professional; also, their HEI staff provide them and their preceptors with additional support (i.e. NMC (UK Nursing and Midwifery Council), 2010; ANMAC, 2017). The terminology for the practice learning overseer varies globally. To date the term 'mentor' has been used in the UK; however, with the introduction of new 2018 NMC *Standards of proficiency for registered nurses (*Nursing and Midwifery Council, 2018a*),* this term will be phased out and students enrolled on newly validated Nursing and Midwifery Council, 2018a programmes will be supported by teams of practice professionals, working in different capacities, to support the students practice learning. The terms for these individuals will be 'Practice Supervisors' and 'Practice Assessors' and the HEI lecturer supporting the student is the 'Academic Assessor' (Nursing and Midwifery Council, 2018b). Due to the varied global terminology and to prevent confusion using historical and modern terms interchangeably, this paper will use the term 'preceptor' when referring to the person overseeing the students learning in practice. The rationale for this being that preceptor is globally preferred terminology, used to describe somebody who offers holistic, one-to-one learning support, when either orientating a registered nurse into their healthcare organisation, or holistically supporting the learning of a nursing student (Ward and McComb, 2018).

When it comes to assuring the quality of nursing students' practice learning, many nations have placed an emphasis on HEI academic staff providing support to the student and their preceptor (i.e. NMC (UK Nursing and Midwifery Council), 2010; ANMAC, 2017). i.e USA, Australia. Traditionally, however, academics have struggled to support students in practice because of their academic work commitments. Notably, in the UK it is unlikely these issues will be relieved by the new Nursing and Midwifery Council (2018a) standards that aim to promote creativity and innovation when supporting practice learning because of a lack of guidelines suggesting how, in challenging times and with constrained resources, this can happen. The central problem, therefore, is that HEI staff will need to support an increasing number of students and preceptors, in more geographically dispersed, non-traditional, practice-based learning environments.

Complicating things further is the pressures of the present political

* Corresponding author.
E-mail addresses: tania.hart@dmu.ac.uk (T. Hart), Robert.farmer@northampton.ac.uk (R. Farmer).
† Deceased

https://doi.org/10.1016/j.nepr.2019.05.009
Received 12 June 2018; Received in revised form 18 April 2019; Accepted 26 May 2019
1471-5953/ Crown Copyright © 2019 Published by Elsevier Ltd. All rights reserved.